

FIVE KEYS AFTER MIDNIGHT

STEP 1b RUN AS A PRE-MORTEM

2026-08-28. The standing champion after roughly 180 lines: **8.5, and the only line Stephen has called "definitely intriguing".**

Five friends receive keys after a woman's murder, each opening the cupboard where she hid proof that one of them planned her death.

★ **This is the first time the earliest-action sweep has been run BEFORE a spine instead of after one.** Both previous candidates cost a full day of spine work before the instrument found the hole. If it can kill a premise from one sentence, it should.

Verdict: SURVIVES. Conditions A and B accepted 2026-08-28. Condition C ruled the same day, after the first three answers were rejected as thin.

What the sentence commits us to

Five things, none of them optional:

1. A woman was murdered.
 2. **She expected it**, enough to hide proof and make an arrangement.
 3. Five friends receive keys **after** she dies, so somebody executed her instruction.
 4. The cupboard holds proof that **one of the five planned it**.
 5. **The five are a closed set.** Each of them is a suspect to the other four.
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The sweep

Person	Earliest competent action	When	Recipient	Recipient's earliest response	Does the episode survive?
★ The first friend to reach the cupboard, if innocent	Open it, read it, take it to the police	★ Hour one	Police	★ A murder victim's own hidden proof, naming her killer. They act immediately	★★ NO. Episode over at lead one
★ The first friend to reach the cupboard, if guilty	Open it and destroy it	★ Hour one	Nobody	Nothing	★ Yes, and this is the only version that works. See condition B
Whoever holds the keys and posts them	Hand the whole arrangement to police, because it came from a murder victim	Day one	Police	★ They open the cupboard themselves before any friend does	★★ NO, unless condition A holds
The other four, once they know	Go to the police together	Within days	Police	"Our dead friend left us keys to an empty cupboard" is not evidence and cannot be acted on	✅ Yes. Correctly, nothing happens
The four, about each other	Talk to each other	Immediately	Each other	★ They cannot, because each of them is a suspect to the other three	✅ Yes, and this is the engine
Ally	Take it from whichever of the four calls her	Day one	Her audience	She has no power and never gains any	✅ Yes

★ THE THREE CONDITIONS

A. Her death was not treated as a murder at the time

Otherwise the arrangement goes straight to police and they open the cupboard first. A solicitor or executor holding an instruction from a murder victim hands it over, and any version where they do not is the *"unbelievable incompetence"* that killed six lines in round one.

So: her death was recorded as an accident, an overdose or a suicide. There was no investigation, so there was nobody for the keys to be given to. ★ That is also the show's own engine, the record being wrong, and it costs nothing.

△ **Consequence to accept now: the murder is not established at the top of the episode. Only the reader knows.** That is the third time this has come up and it needs handling in the opening, not later.

B. The cupboard is already empty

The premise as written cannot survive an innocent person opening it, because that person goes to the police in the first hour and the story ends.

★ **So the killer got there first, and the other four arrive to an empty cupboard.** What survives is not the evidence. It is **the certainty that one of the four people standing there took it**, which is a human problem rather than an evidential one, and it is far better drama.

Reject the alternative — a lock needing all five keys, or five keys to five parts of one proof. **That is a puzzle-box device**, and puzzle-box thinking is exactly what dropped round two's ceiling from 8.5 to 7.5.

C. ★ SOMEBODY ALIVE IS AT RISK. RULED 2026-08-28.

A and B accepted. The first three answers offered here were thin and were rejected; this replaces them.

She had already told somebody. Not one of the five. Somebody outside, who does not know what they were told.

Two years ago she said one ordinary sentence to somebody ordinary — she named who she was meeting, or where she was going, in the way anybody mentions their evening to a person they see every week. **That person has never connected it to her death**, because her death was an accident and there was nothing to connect it to.

The killer knows she talked to someone. The killer has never found out who. For two years that has been the one loose end, and for two years there has been no way to pull it.

★★ **Then a podcast starts asking, in public, on a schedule.**

The investigation is the murder weapon. Every episode Ally publishes narrows the search for a person she is trying to protect, and she cannot stop without abandoning the case.

Why this one and not the others

Test	Result
A specific person, not a mood	✓ One woman, findable, and the player is looking for her too
★ The killer's least-cost action	✓ Listen. He does nothing, spends nothing and risks nothing while somebody else does the work. This is the first candidate in three where sitting still is not the antagonist's best move — because now sitting still and listening IS his best move, and it is lethal
Danger grows because the player acts	✓ Directly and measurably. Every decision to publish is a decision about her
Can the police simply protect her?	✓ No, and it is not a contrivance: nobody knows who she is. You cannot protect a person whose name nobody has. That is a wall the world supplies
Can Ally just stop?	✓ She can, and then the case dies and the woman stays unprotected anyway, because he is still looking. A real trade, not an obvious one
Does it need new art?	One portrait. She is worth it
Is it specific to a podcast?	★★ Completely. A newspaper could not do this and neither could a detective. A serialised public investigation is a search engine the killer could never have built for himself. This is the strongest medium-necessity claim the project has produced

What it gives the episode for free

- **A race with a real finish line.** Ally has to reach her first, along the same trail he is following.
- **The agency gate solved without engineering.** Publishing advances the case and endangers her, every time, and the player feels both.
- **★ The warn-or-not decision.** Telling her makes her safe and tells her she has been a target for two years. Not telling her keeps her ordinary and keeps her exposed.
- **A close that is not tidy.** She was found because a podcast went looking. That is true whichever way it ends.

The one thing to decide at spine time, not now

What she was actually told. It must be so ordinary that not connecting it is obviously reasonable, and decisive the moment it is placed beside the empty cupboard. **It cannot be a clue she sat on. It has to be a Tuesday-evening sentence.**

What the sweep did NOT catch

- **Nothing resolves too fast.** Once the cupboard is empty, the correct official response is that nothing can be done, and that is true rather than convenient.
 - **No route is closed.** Every one of the four can go to the police, and does, and it changes nothing.
 - **No paperwork.** The object is a key and an empty cupboard.
 - **No small number carries a reversal.** Five is a cast size, not a measurement.
 - **No child and no elderly person** is required by anything in the premise.
 - ☒ **The closed set of five is the seam that has been working on this reader all week:** five keys, two sisters with identical statements, four men in a van, three friends telling one story.
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VERDICT

Green. All three conditions closed. Clear to write the spine.

★ **Two spines were written and reworked before this instrument found their hole. This time it took one page and no prose.** If that is all the sweep ever does, it has paid for itself.

Next, in order: the spine · then the pre-flight · then ChatGPT · then one opening from Fable.